

A Grammar of Work

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1. The proposal

A relation is an object.

It has two owners, each the owner of one of the objects it connects, and both commit to the agreements it contains. The relation persists. The objects that fill it can change.

Nothing in a service exists on its own. A target group, a result, a product or an actor exists in a service through a relation. Four regular objects, target group, result, product and actor, and three relation objects between them, objective, contribution and activity, are enough to describe a service. Demand runs from the target group to the result. Supply runs from the actor to the product. They meet in the contribution. A service is the name for that whole.

Because relations are objects, what each part contributes, and to whom, can be seen. And the reach of a change is not estimated. It is traced, relation by relation, to every result it touches and to every owner who must agree.

This paper sets out a grammar of work built on these statements, and shows what it makes visible.

Meridian Group verifies the identity of its customers. Three results rely on that verification: Customer Onboarding, Account Recovery and Contract Formation. The team that forms the verification finding wants to change its reliability scale. The change is small and, seen from inside the team, an improvement. Because each reliance is a relation object with an owner on the other side, the team sees before making the change which three results it reaches and which three owners it must agree with. The change is made together, or not at all.



Figure 1 · A service as relations

2. How it works

A service is read from its centre outwards. The centre is the contribution, where what is offered meets what is asked. From there the chain opens to the right, towards the target group, and to the left, towards the actor.

Every object and every relation object is bound to governance: law, policy, strategy, and those entitled to set them. This paper does not repeat that for each of them. It describes what the objects and their relations are, not where their authority comes from.

The regular object

A service has four regular objects. The target group is those for whom the service matters: the people, organisations or communities who need it and will use it. The result is the condition the service seeks to make true for them. The product is what is formed and delivered, recognisable apart from the effort that formed it. The actor is whoever does the work: a person, a team, an organisational unit, another organisation or a system.

Every regular object has an owner, held as one of its attributes. The owner speaks and commits for the object. That can be a single person, such as a manager or a system owner, or a collective, such as a community or a user group.

A regular object can stand on either side of a relation object. A result can supply another result, just as a product supplies a result. What it is in a service depends on the relations it stands in.



Figure 2 · A result contributing to a result

The relation object

A relation object is defined by the regular objects on either side of it. Without them it has no content. With them, it states what passes between them.

It cuts both ways. Each side commits to what it asks of the other and to what it delivers to the other. Neither side defines the relation alone. Only what both have agreed belongs to it.

A relation object has two owners: the owners of the objects it connects. They make the agreements, they commit to them, and only together can they change them.

A relation object holds one or more agreements. Each states something both owners hold to: what must be delivered, under which conditions it is accepted, and when. Time is agreed in two ways. The first is the moment something must be available, either a date or a point in the order of other agreements. The second is how long it remains valid, as a verification may hold for a year and then need renewal. Quality, time and acceptance are not properties of an object on its own. They are agreements in a relation.

A relation object is read in two ways. Its design holds what has been agreed. Its operation shows what actually happens. Both belong to the same object. Testing is comparing the two, agreement by agreement. When one is not met, the test shows which one, and the two owners know whom to speak to.

A regular object without a relation object does not exist in a service. It may still be present in the organisation.

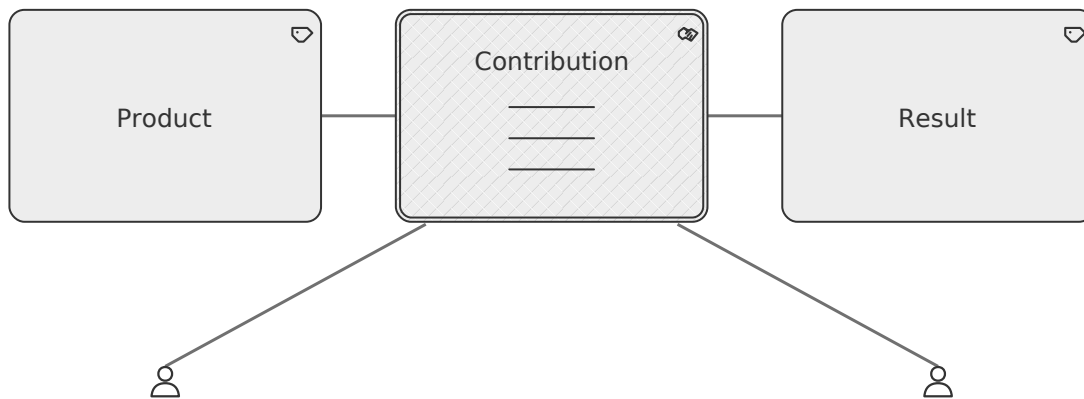


Figure 3 · A relation object up close

In a service

A service holds three relation objects. The contribution connects the product and the result. The objective connects the result and the target group. The activity connects the actor and the product.

In Customer Onboarding, the contribution between the approval decision and the result holds that the decision is formed by someone with the authority to approve, and is available before the account is activated. The objective between the result and new customers holds that a new customer can begin using the relevant services within two working days of a complete application, and that the customer provides the information needed to establish identity. The activity between the credit officer and the approval decision holds that the decision is formed within one working day after the verified record is available, and that the product side makes the record and the current criteria available in time.

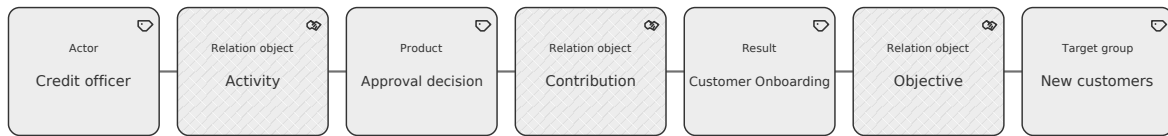


Figure 4 · Customer Onboarding as relations

3. How to begin

There are two ways in. Both end in the same place: a chain in which every regular object stands in a relation object, and every relation object has two owners and their agreements.

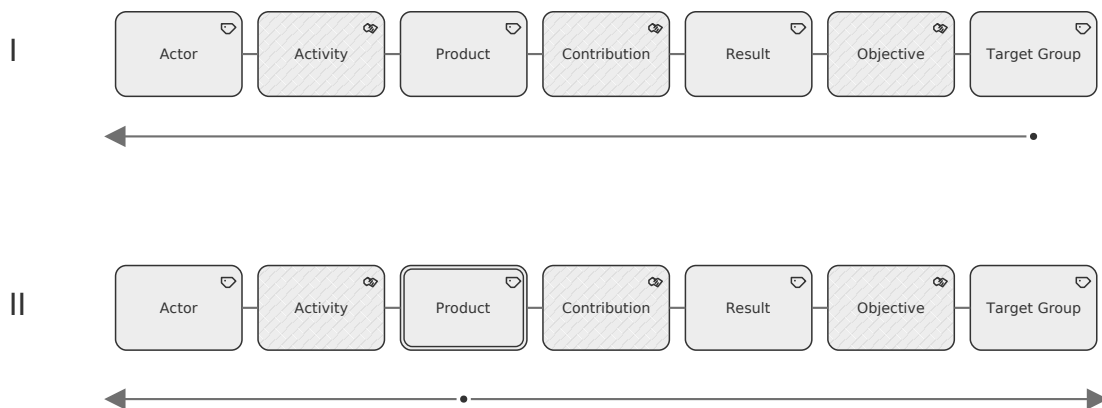


Figure 5 · Two ways in

I. From the target group inwards

Start with those for whom the service matters, and with whoever speaks for them. Ask what must become true for them. That is the result, and what passes between the group and the result is the objective. Then ask what the result needs. Those are the products, each held by a contribution. Then ask who forms each product. That is the actor, held by an activity.

At every step, name both owners and write down what they agree. A step where nobody will commit is the point where the service is not yet a service.

II. From what already exists

Start with something the organisation already makes: a report, a decision, a check, an account. Ask for which result it is made, and who owns that result. If there is an answer, record the contribution and continue outwards from there. If there is none, the product is present in the organisation but exists in no service.

Way I designs a service. Way II uncovers one that already runs. In practice both are used: II finds what is there, I shows what is missing.

Meridian can begin either way. Way I starts with new customers and the customer care manager who speaks for them, and works inwards to the approval decision and the credit officer. Way II starts with the approval decision the credit team already forms, asks for which result it is made, finds Customer Onboarding and its owner, and works outwards from there. Both arrive at the chain in figure 4.

What to write down

For each relation object, three things are enough to begin: the two objects it connects, their two owners, and the agreements, each stating what is delivered, when, for how long and on what terms it is accepted. Nothing more is needed to start.

Six prime activities

What happens inside an activity can be almost anything. To make it clear, six prime activities offer a handhold. Each is named by the product it forms.

Observe forms a registered observation. *Relate* forms an explicit relation between things. *Interpret* forms the meaning of what was observed or related. *Decide* forms a determination: what applies, what is permitted, what will be done. *Make* forms an object or brings something into a required state. *Communicate* makes content available to the one who needs it.

They are not stages and not departments. A single activity may combine several of them. Forming the approval decision means relating the verified record to the criteria, interpreting what the match means, and deciding. Naming them makes visible what the agreement asks of the actor, and therefore what can be tested.

An activity is identified by the product it must form, not by the effort it takes. Many operations may happen along the way, but the activity is complete when its product exists. That product may be held in a document or a system, but the document is its carrier, not the product. Naming the prime activities underneath helps say which product is meant.

4. What it means in practice

The verbs you already use

Organisations describe work in their own verbs. Most of them are derived from the six prime activities, alone or in combination. Recognising which ones lie underneath shows what an activity must form.

Verb in practice	Prime activities
Register, record, log	Observe
Link, match, assign, reconcile	Relate

Verb in practice	Prime activities
Assess, evaluate, diagnose	Interpret
Approve, reject, prioritise, authorise	Decide
Build, configure, activate, repair	Make
Notify, publish, report, inform	Communicate
Analyse	Observe, Relate, Interpret
Review, check, validate	Relate, Interpret, Decide
Process, handle a request	Decide, Make, Communicate

Some verbs cannot be taken apart this way: manage, support, coordinate, facilitate. They name an area of work, not a product. An activity described only by such a verb has no agreement yet. Nobody can say what must be formed, so nothing can be tested. Asking which prime activities lie underneath is the quickest way to turn it into one.

Waste

What an organisation does, but no one uses, exists in the organisation and in no service. That is waste. What an organisation can do but is not asked to do is capacity, and capacity is not waste.

Waste arises from either side of a relation object. In each case one owner acts without the other.

The side that asks can stop using what it agreed to use, change what it asks, or end the relation, while the other side keeps delivering. What is still delivered then serves no one. A service may be built, delivered and reached, and then barely used, or used only years later. Until it is used, what was made exists in the organisation and in no service.

Customer Onboarding automates its approval and no longer needs the credit officer's decision, but nobody tells the credit team. The decision is still formed every day, on time and to standard, for a result that no longer asks for it.

The side that delivers can change what it delivers, while the other side still relies on what was agreed. What is still made then no longer meets the agreement, and the side that relied on it is at risk. If the delivering side simply stops, that is not waste but a gap: nothing is made, and something is missing.

Suppose the team that forms the verification finding changes its reliability scale without consulting anyone. Nothing breaks that day. But the finding no longer meets what Customer Onboarding, Account Recovery and Contract Formation agreed to. Three results are at risk, and for each of them the finding, still produced every day, has become waste. Under this grammar this is visible the moment it happens: three relation objects are broken, and each has an owner on the other side.

Waste travels. If the relation between a result and its target group ends, the products, activities and actors behind that result lose their existence too, unless another relation still carries them to someone who uses them. One ended agreement can turn a whole branch into waste.

Within one service, an object without a relation is a candidate for waste. Only when it stands in no relation in any service is it waste.

Figure 6 shows the delivering side: the contribution is broken, the result is at risk, and the product, still made, no longer exists in the service. When the asking side withdraws, the contribution breaks in the same way, but the result is not at risk; only what is still delivered is waste. In both cases what lies behind the broken relation, the activity that forms the product and the actor that performs it, loses its existence in that service too, unless another relation still carries it.

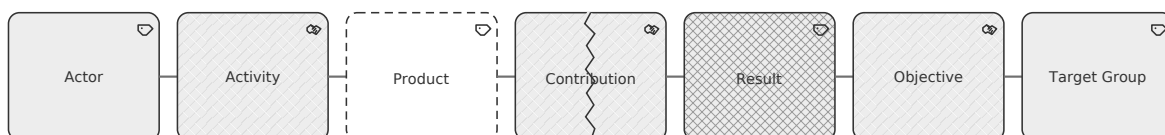


Figure 6 · Waste

Change

The reach of a change is traced, not estimated. Start at the object to be changed and follow its relation objects. Each one leads to an object on the other side and to an owner who must agree. Continue as long as relations lead on. The list of relation objects you pass is also the list of conversations to have.

A change is as large as the chain of agreements it touches, not as large as it looks from inside.

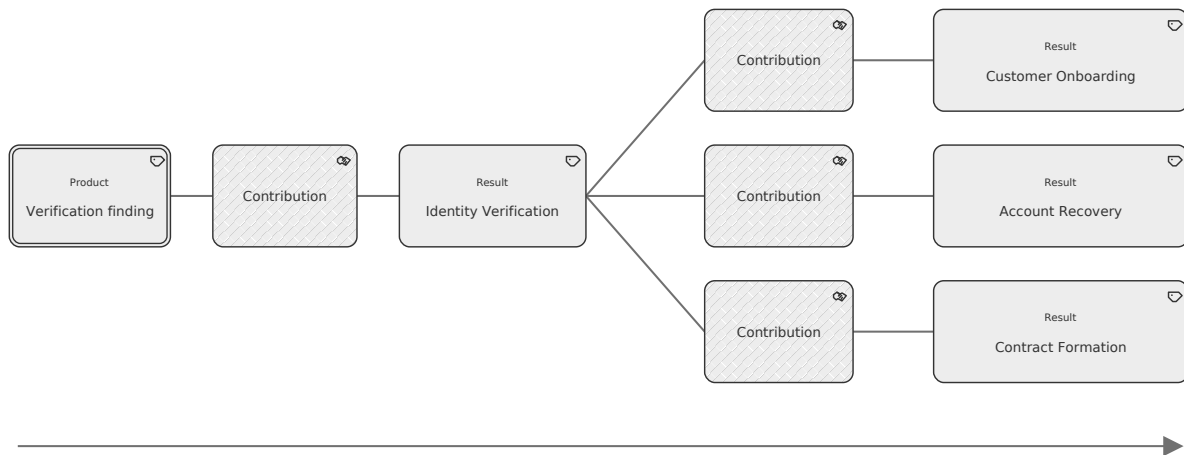


Figure 7 · Tracing a change

Substitution

The relation persists. The objects that fill it can change. Doing work in house, moving it outside, or relying on a result elsewhere is one movement: another object under the same relation object. If the new object meets the agreements, nothing changes for the other side. If it does not, there is a gap on one side and waste on the other.

A new object usually brings a new owner, and a relation object holds only what both owners have committed to. Replacing the object therefore means the new owner commits to the existing agreements, or the agreements are made again.

Meridian moves identity verification to an external provider. The contribution between Identity Verification and Customer Onboarding stays the same. What changes is the object on the supplying side and its owner, who commits to what was already agreed.

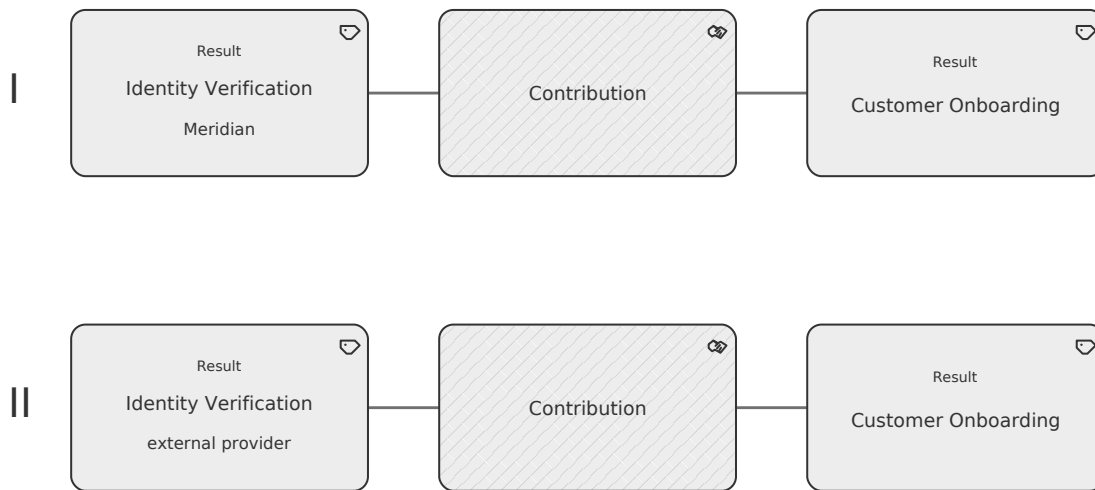


Figure 8 · Substitution

5. What to take into account

Is this bureaucracy?

Recording every relation as an object sounds like administration for its own sake. It is not. The agreements already exist. People already expect things of each other, rely on each other and are disappointed by each other. What is missing is that the expectations are written down and that both sides have committed to them. The price of leaving them implicit is paid elsewhere: in work nobody uses, and in changes that break what nobody saw. Three things per relation object are enough: the two objects, the two owners, the agreements. Begin where something is at stake, not everywhere at once.

Ownership is the hard part

Naming an owner sounds simple and rarely is. Many objects in an organisation have people who work on them but nobody who will commit for them. Without an owner there is no commitment, and without commitment there is no relation. The first finding of this grammar is often not waste, but an object without an owner. Naming one is real work, and it is where the grammar starts to change how an organisation operates.

Capacity is not waste

The grammar shows what is done and not used. It does not say that everything not currently used should go. What an organisation can do but is not asked to do is capacity. Reserves, readiness and room to respond belong there, and the grammar should not be used to cut them.

The grammar shows, owners decide

A broken relation object shows that two owners need to speak. It does not say who is right. Whether a product should be adapted, an agreement remade, or a relation ended remains a judgement of the owners on both sides. The grammar makes that conversation unavoidable, not its outcome predetermined.

Seven, and no more

This grammar describes four regular objects and three relation objects. Much that matters in organisations lies outside it: systems as carriers, information, budgets, people as more than actors. They are not denied. They are deliberately left out, so that what remains can be held precisely.

6. Where it comes from

This grammar follows from the Governance Chain. The Governance Chain describes how principles reach the work: an explicit, traceable chain of relationships from intent to realization, in which every link is stated and none is assumed. Its governance lines are not handed down. They are where governance and realization meet, and they hold because both sides built them.

The Governance Chain describes what an organisation can do: its capabilities, functions and components. This grammar takes the next step and describes what an organisation does, for whom, and with what result. It applies the same principle to the work itself. Relations are explicit, owned on both sides and testable. Demand and supply meet in the contribution, as governance and realization meet in the chain. And the reach of a change is traced, not estimated, in the work as in its governance.

Both grew out of ClaritasZ, a framework for making reality explicit rather than modelling assumptions.

Applied to work, that principle leads to one question: what is actually there between the parts of an organisation, and what is merely assumed? This grammar answers by making the relation the thing that is recorded, owned and committed to, and by letting the parts be what fills it.

That is not a technique. It is a way of seeing. Nothing in a service stands on its own. A product matters because a result relies on it. A result matters because someone uses it. An actor matters because something is formed. Take the relation away, and what remains may still be busy, but it no longer belongs to anything.

Even thinking is relating: connecting what is observed to what it means. Which is why this grammar ends where it began.

I relate, therefore I exist.